Revealing interactions: cross-species sensitivity analysis

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```
ENV["GKSwstype"] = "100"
using MatrixCommunityModels
using Plots, Random, Statistics
```

Interactions as an output

A matrix community model contains no interaction coefficients. Lytle & Tonkin (2023) recover interactions afterwards: change one vital rate of one species and stage a little, project the community, and see how the average abundance of every species and stage responds. Doing this for every vital rate gives a matrix of net effects, which they summarise as a network (their Figs. 2 and 3).

This vignette does that for the riparian guild model of the previous vignette, in its corrected form, perturbing the flood mortality of each of the 30 guild-stages.

One perturbation

`abundance_sensitivity` takes a function that builds the model with the vital rate set to a given value, the values to try, and the environments. `with_rate` makes a copy of the guild parameters with one entry changed.

The flow regime is a random draw of years from the record. The same 20 sequences of 300 years are used for every value of the vital rate, so that differences between runs are due to the vital rate and not to the luck of the draw. The first 100 years are discarded.

```
base = riparian_model(corrected = true)
rng = Xoshiro(1)
sequences = [[rand(rng, base.envs) for _ in 1:300] for _ in 1:20]

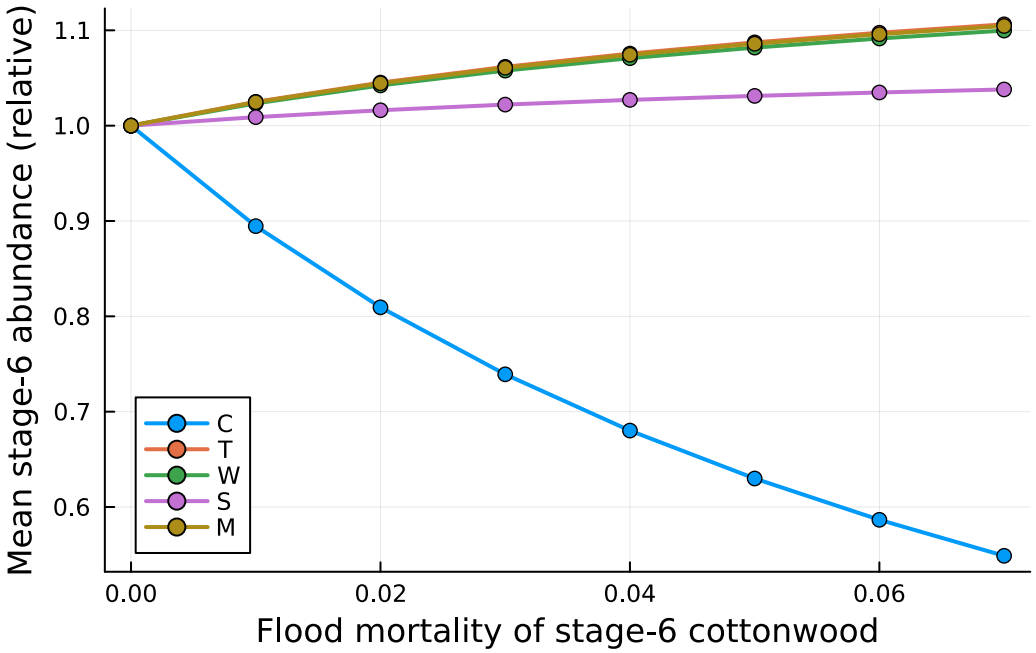
function flood_mortality_sensitivity(guild, stage; envs = r -> sequences[r])
    v0 = RIPARIAN_GUILDS[guild].S[stage]
    values = collect(range(max(0, v0 - 0.05), min(1, v0 + 0.05); step =
 ↪  0.01))
    build(v) = riparian_model(corrected = true, guilds =
     ↪  with_rate(RIPARIAN_GUILDS, guild, :S, stage, v))
    return abundance_sensitivity(build, values, envs; burnin = 100,
     ↪  replicates = 20), values
end

s, values = flood_mortality_sensitivity(:C, 6)
```

```
((slope = [2.8941063716726275e6, 27196.205681559768, 2105.455876929926,
 ↪  1646.043604229914, 4501.0333011967095, -15915.091859500668,
 ↪  1.969616545530645e6, 52826.05724552152, 14679.43775403232,
 ↪  6850.827415677398  …  372.7810906690909, 230.6590467113406,
 ↪  379.4552298321292, 145.77485342139963, 4.480971214369054e6,
 ↪  141077.97103077153, 2356.0381137984723, 1518.4201102228083,
 ↪  6612.51117427275, 25639.221689448957], r2 = [0.9717311055129279,
 ↪  0.9710200664502038, 0.9709392250167993, 0.97082066655274,
 ↪  0.9708003164064941, 0.9706925649639362, 0.9716241514835594,
 ↪  0.9710846942092096, 0.970949281606067, 0.9708609492387071  …
 ↪  0.9731463538561256, 0.9731971559946676, 0.9728544662141038,
 ↪  0.9692801046060228, 0.971636988565778, 0.9707272373605086,
 ↪  0.9705353436822334, 0.9706850578605656, 0.9705445669957481,
 ↪  0.9696693119531941], means = [2.0510122977463552e6 19190.51110059933 …
 ↪  4653.482648724525 17561.953159658784; 2.098966811424761e6
 ↪  19643.412957252818 … 4764.307129655869 17994.475076211842; … ;
 ↪  2.240470991118772e6 20972.779170096965 … 5087.254061803725
 ↪  19246.031069491335; 2.2579751849963004e6 21135.958286870202 …
 ↪  5126.790114443041 19398.086000516945]), [0.0, 0.01, 0.02, 0.03, 0.04,
 ↪  0.05, 0.06, 0.07])
```

The response of mature (stage 6) individuals of each guild to the flood mortality of mature cottonwood:

```
guilds = [:C, :T, :W, :S, :M]
mature = 6:6:30
plot(values, s.means[:, mature] ./ s.means[1:1, mature]; label =
 ↪  permutedims(String.(guilds)),
     xlabel = "Flood mortality of stage-6 cottonwood", ylabel = "Mean
 ↪  stage-6 abundance (relative)",
     marker = :circle, lw = 2)
```



Killing more mature cottonwood in floods reduces cottonwood and lets every other guild increase: competition, although the model has no competition coefficient.

```
(slope = round.(s.slope[mature]; digits = 1), r2 = round.(s.r2[mature];
 ↪  digits = 3))
```

```
(slope = [-15915.1, 10007.8, 16308.0, 145.8, 25639.2], r2 = [0.971, 0.97,
 ↪  0.97, 0.969, 0.97])
```

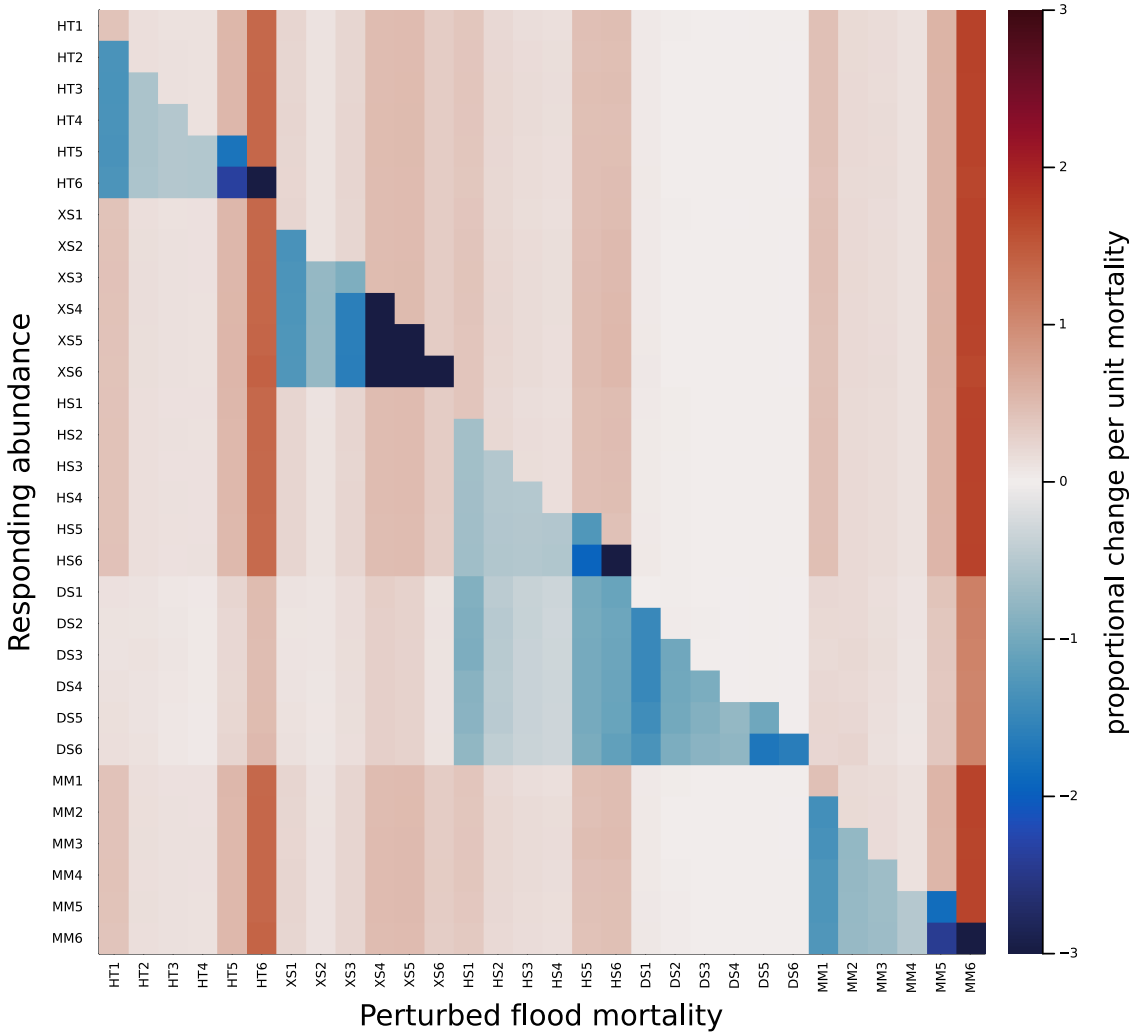
The full matrix

```
labels = [string(g, i) for g in ("HT", "XS", "HS", "DS", "MM") for i in 1:6]
slope = zeros(30, 30)
r2 = zeros(30, 30)
for (a, g) in enumerate(guilds), i in 1:6
```

```
    res, _ = flood_mortality_sensitivity(g, i)
    slope[:, (a - 1) * 6 + i] = res.slope
    r2[:, (a - 1) * 6 + i] = res.r2
end
```

Column `j` holds the effect of the flood mortality of guild-stage `j` on the mean abundance of every guild-stage (rows). To compare stages whose abundances differ by orders of magnitude, each row is divided by that stage's mean abundance in the unperturbed model, giving the proportional change in abundance per unit of mortality. (Guild labels follow the paper: HT cottonwood, XS tamarisk, HS willow, DS sagebrush, MM meadow.)

```
baseline = mean(mean_abundance(base.community, base.n0, q; burnin = 100)
 ↪  for q in sequences)
effect = slope ./ baseline
heatmap(labels, labels, clamp.(effect, -3, 3); yflip = true, color =
 ↪  :balance, clims = (-3, 3),
        xrotation = 90, xticks = (0.5:1:29.5, labels), yticks = (0.5:1:29.5,
 ↪  labels), tickfontsize = 5,
        xlabel = "Perturbed flood mortality", ylabel = "Responding
 ↪  abundance", size = (650, 600),
        colorbar_title = "proportional change per unit mortality")
```



Red cells are positive effects (the responding stage gains when the perturbed stage suffers more in floods) and blue cells negative. The diagonal blocks are within-guild effects. Two features stand out:

```
(positive = count(effect .> 0), negative = count(effect .< 0),
 negative_within_guild = count(effect[i, j] < 0 for i in 1:30, j in 1:30 if
 ↪  (i - 1) ÷ 6 == (j - 1) ÷ 6))
```

```
(positive = 776, negative = 124, negative_within_guild = 88)
```

Most effects between guilds are positive, that is, competitive. The clearest exception is sagebrush (DS), which declines when willow (HS) suffers more in floods, a net positive effect of willow on sagebrush that no one put into the model. And the effect of a stage's mortality on its own abundance is not always negative:

```
[labels[k] => round(effect[k, k]; digits = 2) for k in (1, 6, 13, 18)]
```

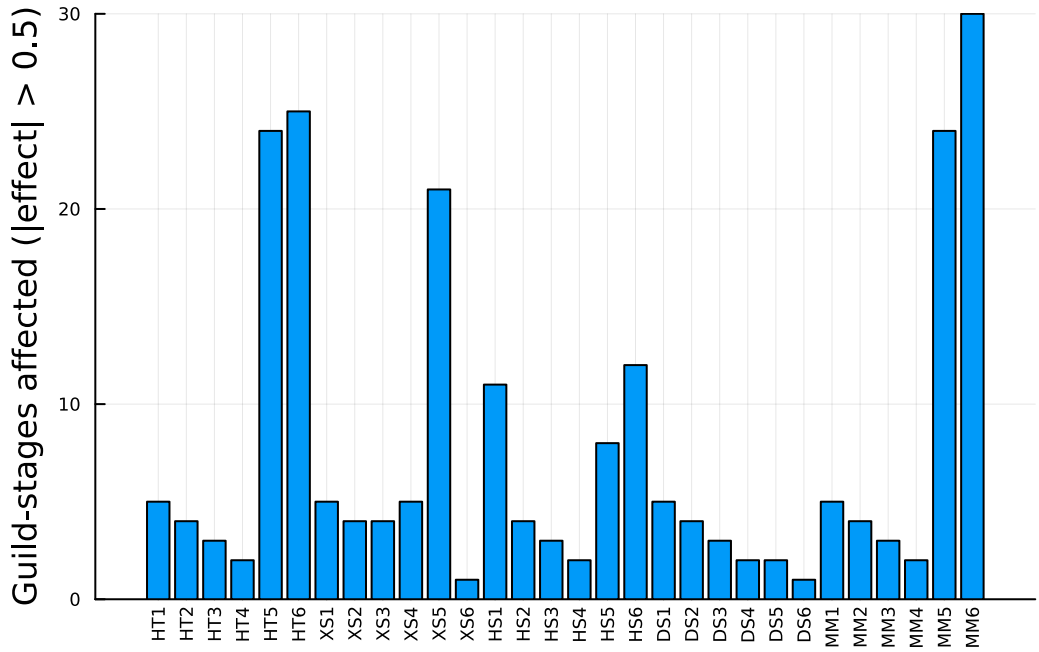
```
4-element Vector{Pair{String, Float64}}:
 "HT1" => 0.43
 "HT6" => -7.79
 "HS1" => 0.4
 "HS6" => -3.52
```

More flood mortality of seedlings (stage 1) *increases* the average number of seedlings of that guild, because the space freed is recolonised by new seedlings and recruitment in this model does not depend on the number of adults.

Which stages matter most

Counting, for each perturbed stage, how many guild-stages change by more than half their abundance per unit of mortality gives a simple measure of influence:

```
influence = vec(sum(abs.(effect) .> 0.5; dims = 1))
bar(labels, influence; xrotation = 90, legend = false, xticks = (0.5:1:29.5,
 ↪  labels), tickfontsize = 6,
    ylabel = "Guild-stages affected (|effect| > 0.5)")
```



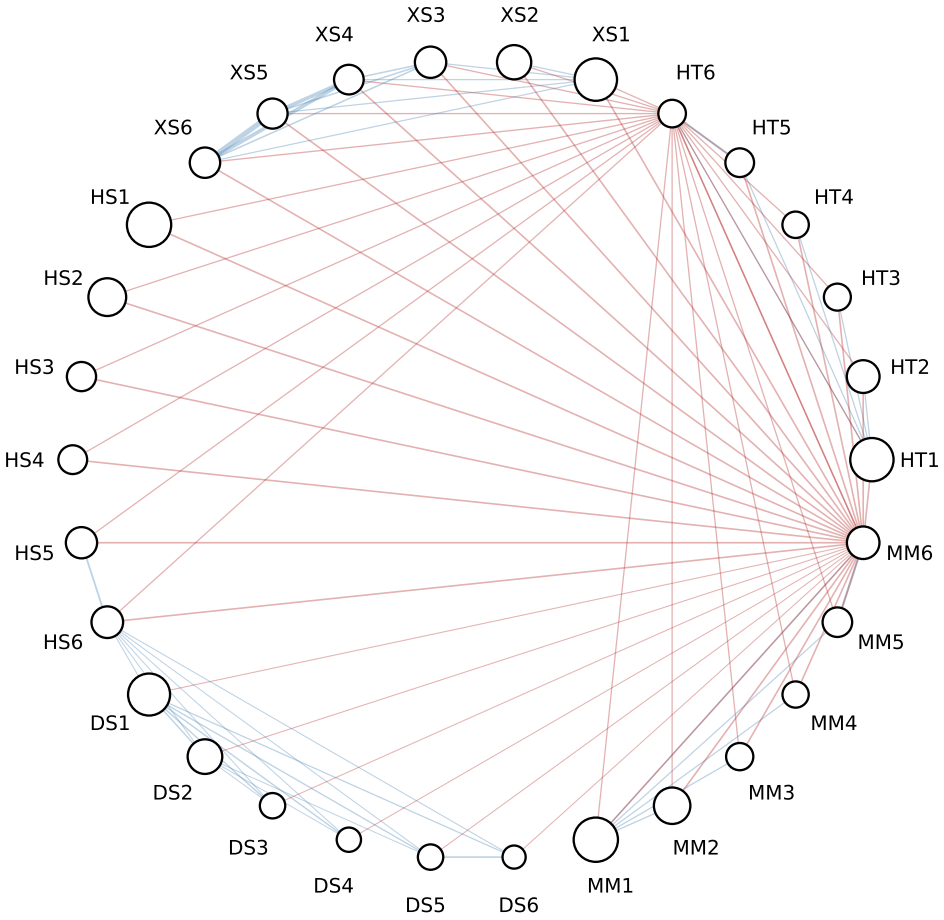
The older stages of cottonwood (HT5, HT6) and meadow (MM5, MM6), and stage-5 tamarisk, affect almost the whole community. Lytle & Tonkin single out mature cottonwood (HT6) as

a keystone of this system. Their analysis used the original model, so the two are not directly comparable, but the same stage emerges here.

The network

The matrix can be drawn as a directed network: an arrow from the perturbed stage to each stage it strongly affects.

```
θ = range(0, 2π; length = 31)[1:30]
x, y = cos.(θ), sin.(θ)
p = plot(; aspect_ratio = 1, axis = false, grid = false, legend = false,
 ↪  size = (600, 600),
         xlims = (-1.3, 1.3), ylims = (-1.3, 1.3))
for j in 1:30, i in 1:30
    (i != j && abs(effect[i, j]) > 1) || continue
    plot!(p, [x[j], x[i]], [y[j], y[i]]; color = effect[i, j] > 0 ?
     ↪  :firebrick : :steelblue,
          alpha = 0.35, lw = min(abs(effect[i, j]), 6) / 2)
end
scatter!(p, x, y; ms = 3 .+ 1.5 .* log10.(baseline .+ 1), color = :white,
 ↪  markerstrokecolor = :black)
annotate!(p, [(1.12 * x[k], 1.12 * y[k], text(labels[k], 7)) for k in 1:30])
p
```



Red links are positive effects, blue negative; node size reflects mean abundance.

A note on R^2

The paper keeps only relationships with R^2 above 0.3. Here every relationship has an R^2 close to one:

```
quantile(vec(r2), [0.05, 0.5, 0.95])
```

```
3-element Vector{Float64}:
 0.9709487787766036
 0.9999048761747208
```

```
0.9999949280840726
```

That is a consequence of using the same flow sequences for every value of the vital rate. If each run draws its own sequence, as in the original analysis, sampling noise is added to every point and R^2 falls, most for the weakest effects:

```
rng2 = Xoshiro(2)
noisy, _ = flood_mortality_sensitivity(:C, 6; envs = r -> [rand(rng2,
 ↪  base.envs) for _ in 1:300])
(common_sequences = round.(s.r2[mature]; digits = 2), independent_sequences
 ↪  = round.(noisy.r2[mature]; digits = 2),
 slope_common = round.(s.slope[mature]; digits = 1), slope_independent =
 ↪  round.(noisy.slope[mature]; digits = 1))
```

```
(common_sequences = [0.97, 0.97, 0.97, 0.97, 0.97], independent_sequences =
 ↪  [0.96, 0.5, 0.54, 0.01, 0.48], slope_common = [-15915.1, 10007.8,
 ↪  16308.0, 145.8, 25639.2], slope_independent = [-16458.1, 8335.0,
 ↪  26528.6, 93.4, 29739.2])
```

With common sequences the R^2 filter is not needed to separate signal from noise, and far fewer replicates are required; the size of the effect is the more useful criterion.

Reference

Lytle, D. A. & Tonkin, J. D. (2023). Matrix community models for ecology and evolution. *npj Biodiversity* 2, 26.

Tonkin, J. D., Merritt, D. M., Olden, J. D., Reynolds, L. V. & Lytle, D. A. (2018). Flow regime alteration degrades ecological networks in riparian ecosystems. *Nature Ecology & Evolution* 2, 86-93.